7 Elections in India

Learning Outcomes

The learner:

- explains the process of holding elections in our country.
- outlines the role of the Election Commission and political parties.
- lists the different steps of an election.
- recognizes the importance of voting and choosing the right representatives.

Let's Take-off

TP

Experiential Learning

You can choose a captain for your class by voting. This is how:

- Make three or four groups or 'parties'.
- Each party chooses a **candidate** who will stand for election.
- The candidates and parties decide what they will say to voters to persuade them to vote for them.
- The candidates make a short speech asking for votes.
- On a piece of paper, each voter in the class writes the name of the person they choose and gives it to the teacher after folding it.
- The teacher counts the votes.
- The candidate who gets the most votes becomes the class captain.

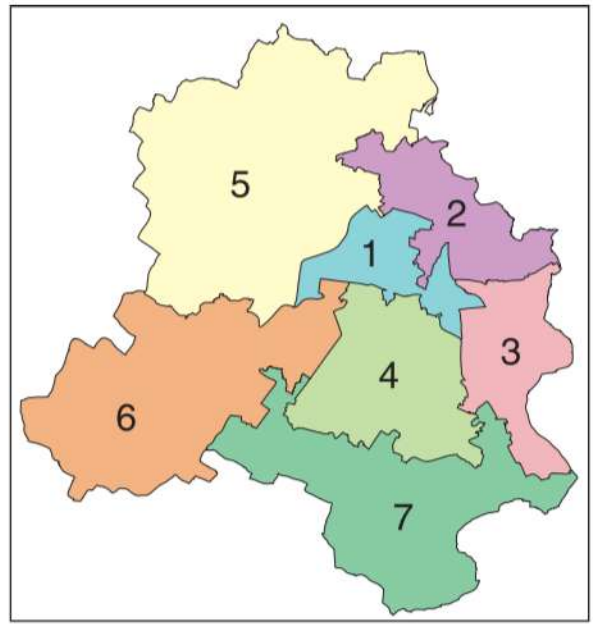
Just as you voted in an election, the Indian people also vote in elections. In **national elections**, people vote to elect members of the Lok Sabha. In **state elections**, people vote to elect members of the Legislative Assembly.

CONSTITUENCIES

For an election, the whole country is divided into parts. Each part is called a **constituency**. Usually several candidates stand for election from a constituency. The person who wins the

election becomes the **representative** of the people of that constituency.

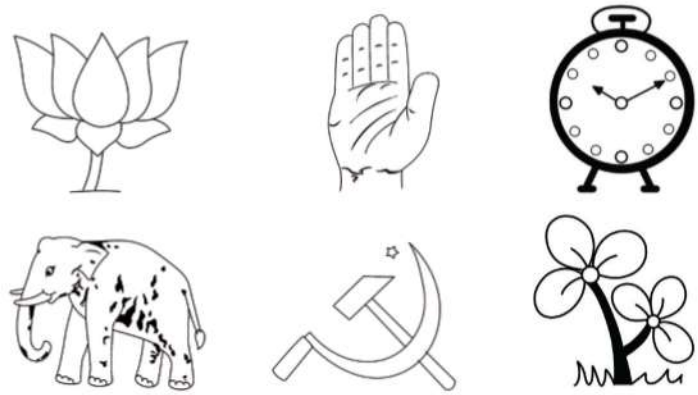
Constituencies for a national election are bigger than for a state election. For example, Delhi has seven constituencies for a national election but the same area has 70 constituencies for a state election (see the map here).



The seven Parliamentary constituencies of Delhi—The same area is divided into 70 Assembly constituencies.

POLITICAL PARTIES AND CANDIDATES

A political party is a group of people who have the same ideas about how a government should work. India has many political parties. Each party has an **election symbol**. The parties select candidates to stand for election from each constituency. They then ask people to vote for them through rallies, speeches, advertisements and posters. This helps the voters to decide whom they would like to vote for.


Symbols of some political parties of India

THE ELECTION COMMISSION

The Election Commission organizes each election. It makes sure that elections are held in the right way. Like the judiciary, the Election Commission is an independent organization.

HOTS Critical Thinking 21st Century Skills

Why do you think that the Constitution made the Election Commission an independent organization? C-6.1

Did You Know?

The first elections in independent India took place in 1951–52. Since then elections have been held regularly to elect governments to rule the country.

Before the Eection

Any Indian citizen, who is 18 years of age or older, has the right to vote. All such citizens have to register as voters with the Election Commission. There are given a Voter ID Card. The Election Commission prepares an **electoral roll** that has the names of all registered voters.

The Election Commission announces the dates for the elections. This includes the voting dates for each constituency as well as the date on which the votes will be counted. It sets up **polling booths** in each constituency where people go to vote.

On Polling Day

The Election Commission makes arrangements so that people can vote freely, without being afraid. Many policemen are on duty to make sure that everything remains peaceful.

A queue of voters outside a polling booth holding up their voter ID cards. To be able to vote, they must show this card to the Election Commission officials in the booth.

Inside the polling booth

One finger of the voter is marked with ink that cannot be removed for several days. The voter goes behind a screen. This has an **electronic voting machine** (EVM) with the names and election symbols of the candidates in that constituency. The voter has to press a button next to the symbol of the chosen candidate. Those who are unable to read, recognize the symbol and press the right button. No one can see which candidate the voter has voted for. This is called a secret **ballot**.

A voter showing her finger marked with ink—Why are voters' fingers marked with this kind of ink?

Think and Answer

21st Century Skills

Critical Thinking

Why is it necessary for people to carry and show their voter ID cards? C-6.1

A Better World

Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)

Goal 5: Gender Equality

In many countries, women did not enjoy the right to vote until recent times. In India, all citizens above the age of 18 have the right to vote. How do you think this helps to promote gender equality? C-6.1

DECLARATION OF RESULTS

Discuss

Communication

Why is there a secret ballot? Why did you fold your voting paper before giving it to your teacher? C-6.1

The Election Commission organizes the counting of votes and announces the results. The EVMs make it easy to count the votes. The candidate who gets the most votes in a constituency is elected as the representative of the people of the constituency. After the results are declared, the members of the new Lok Sabha or the new Legislative Assembly meet. The leader of the party with the most members in the house will be the Prime Minister or the Chief Minister. This party forms the government. The members of the other parties form the **opposition**. It is their responsibility to ask the government questions about its policies and act as a check on their power.

THE IMPORTANCE OF VOTING

The public must be aware of how their representatives are carrying out their duties. This will help them to decide who to vote for in the next election. If elected members do not work for the people or carry out the promises they made, they may not get re-elected. This is why the people of a country are powerful in a democracy .

Knowledge of India

Tashigang, a tiny village in Himachal Pradesh, is currently the world's highest polling station. It is near the India-China border in the Spiti Valley and sits at an altitude of around 15,256 feet.

It is the duty of citizens of voting age to vote in every election. They must make their choice very carefully after thinking about each candidate. Many registered voters do not vote. One reason is that they think that their vote will not make a difference among many millions of votes. However, every vote can make a difference. For example, if enough people feel that protection of the environment is important, and they vote for candidates who promise to protect it, their votes can help to protect the environment. People power, through elections, helps to keep a democratic system functioning well. It is every citizen's responsibility to make sure that this happens.

Values and Life Skills

- Why should citizens debate and discuss the work of politicians?

REMEMBER

Elections in India

- The country and the states are divided into constituencies.
- Political parties select candidates for each constituency.
- The Election Commission supervises elections in India.
- All Indian citizens of 18 years or above have the right to vote.
- The political party that has the most winning candidates forms the government.
- It is the duty of all eligible citizens to vote in elections.

NEW WORDS

Candidate	a person who stands for election
Constituency	a part of a city, state or country that has its own elected representative
Representative	a person who has been chosen on behalf of a group
Electoral roll	the official list of people who have the right to vote in a particular area
Polling booth	a small place separated from the surrounding area, where people vote
Ballot	a system of voting, usually in secret
Opposition	political parties that are in a parliament but are not part of the government

EXERCISES

Remembering and Understanding

A. Choose the correct answer.

1. Constituencies for national elections are bigger/smaller/the same size as constituencies for state elections.
2. An election symbol is given to each constituency/to each political party/to the Election Commission.

3. The Election Commission/President/Prime Minister is responsible for making sure that people can vote freely.
4. In an EVM, people write on a paper/press a button/mark X on a card to choose their candidate.
5. Read the statements below and choose the correct option.
   Statement (A): Every eligible voter can vote only once in elections.
   Statement (B): Voters' fingers are marked with ink that takes many days to fade.
   (a) Both A and B are true, and B is the correct explanation of A.
   (b) Both A and B are true, but B is not the correct explanation of A.
   (c) A is true but B is false.
   (d) A is false but B is true.

B. Fill in the blanks.

1. Every ..... elects its own representative for the government.
2. The ..... is an independent organization.
3. In India the voting age is ..... years and above.
4. The political party that has the most winning candidates forms the ..... .
5. The ..... is made up of those elected members whose party did not win the election.

C. Match the following.

A	B
1. Electoral roll	(a) A part of a country or a state which has its own elected representative
2. Polling booth	(b) A person who stands for election
3. Constituency	(c) Issued by the Election Commission to registered voters
4. Voter ID card	(d) The place where people go to vote
5. Candidate	(e) Contains the names of all registered voters

D. The election in your class

Write a paragraph about the election process in your class. Include these points:

1. Did the groups choose good candidates?
2. Did these candidates give good reasons why they should be elected?
3. Whom did you vote for and why?
4. Which is better—the teacher appoints a class captain or the class chooses a captain? Why?

E. Answer the following questions.

1. What is a political party?
2. Why do candidates make speeches to the people of their constituency?
3. Why do you think that voting is done by a secret ballot?
4. After an election, which political party forms the government and what is the role of the other parties? Write a few sentences about this.
5. Who has power in a democracy? Why?
6. Why is it the duty of citizens to vote? Explain in a few sentences.

DO AND LEARN

A. Picture Study

Look at the picture and answer the questions:
For many years paper ballots were used in India. Now EVMs are used. Why do you think this is so? C-6.1 Critical Thinking

B. On Your Own

Talk to people around you—in your family and others who work in or around your home. Ask them:

1. Did they vote in the last election? If not, why not?
2. If they voted, ask them why they voted. Research-based

C. In a Group

Find out the following. Choose a leader from your group who can then make a presentation to the whole class.

1. When was the last election for the union government?
2. When was the last election in your state?
3. What are the symbols of the parties that form the governments in the centre and your state? C-6.1 Collaboration SI Computer Science

An electronic voting machine—when a voter presses the blue button, the red light beside it comes on.

D. Pair and Share: With your partner in class, discuss what would have happened if women were not allowed to vote in elections. C-6.1 Communication

Weblink For more information, go to:

The Election Question | Learn the importance of elections: • https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2aUxNi4c2fk (Accessed on 31 July 2025)

What I Learnt

Self-review

Colour the smileys to show how well you have understood the concepts.	Completely	Mostly	Need help
• I can explain the process of holding elections in our country.	☺	☺	☺
• I can outline the role of the Election Commission and political parties.	☺	☺	☺
• I can list the different steps of an election.	☺	☺	☺
• I can recognize the importance of voting and choosing the right representatives.	☺	☺	☺